

The Violence of the Old Testament

The conquest chapters are in the book, and the skeptic who refuses to look away is reading more honestly than the churchgoer who skips them. The hardest ground in Scripture, walked slowly.

THE PROBLEM

Reading the Texts We Skip

Deuteronomy 7 commands Israel to devote seven Canaanite nations to complete destruction and show them no mercy. Deuteronomy 20 says that in the cities God gives Israel as an inheritance, nothing that breathes shall be left alive. Joshua reports the command carried out at Jericho, at Ai, at Hazor. The Hebrew word is *herem*, devoted to destruction, and no honest reader gets to pretend it is not there.

I have watched congregations read around these chapters for years, and I have built preaching calendars that did the same. The skeptic who stops cold at Joshua and says, I cannot worship a God who orders this, is taking the text more seriously than the believer who never noticed it. So this guide will not begin with reassurance. It begins by agreeing that the question is real, the texts are hard, and the standard escape routes, allegory on one side and a shrug on the other, are both too cheap.

What a reader owes any ancient text is to ask what its words meant in its world before deciding what they mean for ours. That is not evasion. It is the same rule we apply to every other document from the ancient Near East.

THE RHETORIC

How Ancient War Accounts Talk

Ancient Near Eastern conquest accounts were a literary genre with conventions, and K. Lawson Younger spent a career documenting them. Egyptian, Hittite, and Assyrian kings routinely claimed total annihilation of enemies who reappear, alive and fighting, a paragraph or a decade later. Pharaoh Merneptah's stele announces around 1208 BC that Israel is laid waste and his seed is no more, which would be news to everyone since. Mesha of Moab boasts that Israel utterly perished forever. This was the recognized idiom of victory, totalizing rhetoric that no ancient reader mistook for arithmetic.

Joshua talks the same way, and then corrects itself in plain sight. Joshua 10 and 11 declare that nothing

was left that breathed, yet Joshua 23 warns Israel about the nations still living among them, and Judges 1 opens with a long list of Canaanites never driven out. Either the book contradicts itself within a few pages, or it is using its world's war rhetoric exactly as its neighbors did. Kenneth Kitchen reads it the second way, and he has read more of these texts than nearly anyone alive.

Add that Jericho, Ai, and Hazor functioned as walled military strongpoints more than civilian population centers, as John Walton has argued, and the picture sharpens, though it does not yet soften the command itself.

THE GROUNDS

A Judgment With a Four-Century Fuse

The texts give their own grounds, and the grounds are moral, not ethnic. In Genesis 15 God tells Abraham his descendants will wait four hundred years in someone else's country, because the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete. Whatever else that sentence is, it is patience. Deuteronomy 9 then strips Israel of any flattery. Not because of your righteousness, the nations are being driven out for their wickedness, and you are a stiff-necked people. The same books promise Israel the identical judgment, exile and dispossession, if Israel does the same things, and the prophets record that the promise was kept.

The boundary line, on the texts' own terms, was never blood. Rahab the Canaanite and her whole family are taken in. Achan the Israelite is devoted to destruction. The Canaanite practices the texts name include child sacrifice, which Israel's own God describes with something like horror.

Does this resolve the difficulty? No. A judgment that falls on a generation still falls on the people in it, and saying so out loud is part of reading honestly. What it removes is one specific charge. This is not ethnic cleansing in the texts' own logic. It is judgment with a long fuse, aimed at deeds, and later aimed at Israel too.

THE TABLE

Three Readings Held by Honest People

Careful and faithful readers divide three ways, and you should see each at full strength.

The first takes the commands straight. God, who gives every life, holds the right to end life and to announce judgment through historical events, and this was a unique, unrepeatable command tied to one land and one moment, never a general license. Its cost is that the reader must say the words divine judgment about an event that included children, and the tradition's most serious voices have said them with trembling.

The second reads the commands themselves inside the war rhetoric described above. The conquest in practice meant driving out and breaking military power, the totalizing language is conventional

hyperbole, and the books signal as much by their own internal evidence. Paul Copan and Younger argue this. Its cost is the standing suspicion that it sands down what the text says.

The third reads toward Christ. The conquest is an Old Testament shadow whose terminus is the cross, where the judgment of God falls on God himself, and herem is heard from the far side of Good Friday. Its cost is that the original event still happened to the original people.

I will not adjudicate this in a guide. People who love this text hold each position. The worst reading is the one that finds the question easy.

THE FENCE

What No One May Do With These Texts

One thing is forbidden, and the texts themselves forbid it. Herem was bounded on every side, one land, one moment in the story, tied to a direct command, never extended by the prophets, never invoked for empire, and ended. Israel's later kings are never told to repeat it. The New Testament closes the door entirely. When James and John ask Jesus to call down fire on a Samaritan village, with Elijah as their proof text, he turns and rebukes them. The kingdom he announces conquers by a cross, and its only sword in Paul's letters is the word.

So no modern nation may claim these chapters. Not mine, not anyone's, not any army blessing its artillery with Joshua's name. The crusaders preached these texts at Jerusalem in 1099 and waded in blood. Colonists preached Canaan over the Pequots in 1637. Those sermons were not readings of the text. They were thefts of it, and the church that preached them, my church in the long sense of the word, owns the failure.

What remains is a hard book that refuses to become a weapon, and a question that refuses to become small. You may close Joshua unconvinced. You may not close it unchanged, and neither may I.

KEY TEXTS

Genesis 15:13-16

Deuteronomy 9:4-6

Luke 9:51-56

SOURCES

Ancient Conquest Accounts: A Study in Ancient Near Eastern and Biblical History Writing — K. Lawson Younger Jr.

Is God a Moral Monster? Making Sense of the Old Testament God — Paul Copan

On the Reliability of the Old Testament — Kenneth A. Kitchen

